human rights are all essential if Myanmar is to make progress toward becoming a key regional player in Southeast Asia.

Armed conflict between the government and ethnic minorities has been endemic since independence was granted in the late 1940s. The toll on both combatants and civilians has been enormous. Estimates of over 10,000 deaths per year since independence is noted by Martin Smith in his seminal work *Burma: Insurgency and the Politics of Ethnicity.* In addition to the death toll, the economic devastation, including civilians maimed by landmines, villages destroyed by military operations, and the dislocation of hundreds of thousands has been significant. The social costs, including a burden on health care and education, as well as psychological trauma, are incalculable. With a new administration in place, a unique opportunity to resolve some of these longstanding grievances could be undertaken.

Numerous factors will create challenges for peace initiatives undertaken by any of the parties involved either directly or indirectly. First, several unresolved issues have yet to be addressed by the Myanmar government. Ceasefires have been ironed out on numerous occasions only to be short-lived. This is partially because of a lack of trust as well as a lack of serious concessions on the part of the regime. Several insurgent groups also profit from the illicit narco-criminal undertakings. A final political settlement could undermine these nefarious operations. Most of the insurgents will not disarm, which the government requires if any final resolution is to be agreed upon.

The continuation of multiple armed conflicts with ethnic insurgents also helps to legitimize the need for military rule. It also helps to support the enormous military presence throughout the country. Millions of jobs are based on the military complex, which has been in place for nearly five decades. This gives the military undue political and economic influence throughout Myanmar. Ultimately, this war economy continues to hamper any attempts at legitimate economic gains for the country.

No tangible movement to advance peace and reconciliation between the government and ethnic insurgents has been advocated. This is partially because the government has continually advanced a divide-and-conquer mindset when dealing with ethnic groups. No sort of unity between the numerous ethnic factions has been solidified, which has at times played into